Guide to Letters to Elma and Elma's diary

Letters to Elma:
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1AYYdLls9-Q9GX0WNGIxoXgt_6Ne4jr6-bvVPd43UsGg/edit?usp=sharing
Elma's Diary:
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1v3jewbCoq3mP-7qKevFgUA5WSX795oqW1VDxc3zAm_c/edit?usp=sharing

Letters to Elma **3**

Elma's Diary **13**

Structure

Yorushika's first 2 albums, Dakara Boku wa Ongaku wo Yameta (That's Why I Quit Music, 2019) and Elma (2019), are concept albums with a connected story. The story is told partially from the lyrics, but mostly from the supplementary text that comes with the albums: Letters to Elma for Dakaboku, and Elma's diary for Elma.

Fundamentally speaking, the story is about Amy (the protagonist of Dakaboku) going on a journey through Sweden, and then Elma (protagonist of Elma, duh) taking the same journey one year later in Elma. Letters to Elma are a collection of letters and songs that are (in story) written by Amy, then later mailed in a box to Elma along with some photos. Elma's diary is, well, just what it sounds like. All the songs are written by either Amy or Elma. Elma is told in straight chronological order, while Dakaboku is more ambiguous in its storytelling. Here is a chart for each track's place in the album (A being Dakaboku, or rather, written by Amy, while E is Elma).

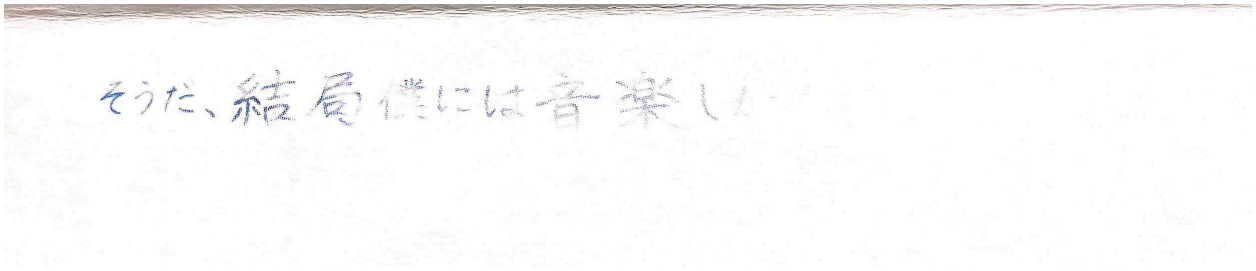
A 02	藍二乗 / Ai Nijou	3/21
A 04	詩書きとコーヒー / Poemu kaki to Coffee	4/24
A 08	五月は花緑青の窓辺から / Go-gatsu wa Hana Rokushou no Madobe Kara	5/15
A 07	六月は雨上がりの街を書く / Roku-gatsu wa Ameagari no Machi wo Kaku	5/31
A 06	踊ろうぜ / Odorou ze	6/15
A 09	夜紛い / Yoru Magai	7/1
A 11	パレード / Parade	7/2
A 03	八月、某、月明かり / Hacigatsu, Bou, Tsukiakari	8/7
A 14	だから僕は音楽を辞めた / Dakara Boku wa Ongaku wo Yameta	8/25
A 12	エルマ / Elma	8/31
E 03	夕凪、某、花惑い / Yuunagi, Bou, Hanamadoi	3/22
E 05	神様のダンス / Kamisama no Dansu	5/28
E 06	雨晴るる / Ame Hare Ruru	6/30
E 07	歩く / Aruku	7/8
E 11	声 / Koe	7/28
E 04	雨とカプチーノ / Ame to Cappucino	9/3
E 02	憂一乗 / Urei Ichijou	9/5
E 09	心に穴が空いた / Kokoro ni Ana ga Aita	9/6
E 14	エイミー / Amy	9/16
E 12	ノーチラス / Nautilus	?

The dates are a bit more ambiguous, as per a small detail mentioned in Elma's diary. Amy had the habit of opening his diary to write an entry, but only writes the date on the page and nothing else. He would then later use that blank page to write a song, so the dates given for each Dakaboku song is highly unreliable.

Now to the actual summary.

Letters to Elma

Amy's letters begin with a letter titled 8/31, which is one of the last letters Amy wrote chronologically. He details the contents of the box his letters are in, being a collection of songs, letters, and photos all created during his journey throughout Sweden. He says all are made specifically for Elma. 8/31 ends with the ink running out on the sentence "Yes, in the end music was to me"



As shown here.

The next letter is the earliest at 3/14, which contains Amy's musing about whether art imitates life or life imitates art. He confesses that he quit his part-time job last summer, and highlights how music is everything to him. He also states how he's frustrated that to make art, a functional body is required. This is a subtle hint for later things to come. The song after this is Ai Nijou, dated 3/21. It's more or less an overview of the album conceptually, touching on many different things, primarily drawing a connection between stuck gazing at the sky and longing for Elma. Many parts of it are later explored as main themes in later songs or letters. A particularly important line is:

Life is just one compromise after another
I learned that pretty fast
Elma, it's you
You alone are my music

Knowing this is necessary to understand many of the lyrics.

Immediately after is Hachigatsu, Bou, Tsukiakari dated 8/7. The lyrics are mostly about Amy's neurotic attitude in regards to, well, just about everything. The chorus is literally him bitching about how everything (mostly himself) is the worst and how he doesn't need anything at all. A repeated line does make an important hint though:

My heart became irritated; as I walked, it got hard to breathe
When I first ran away from my part-time job

and

My heart became irritated
I laughed until my throat went dry
The first time I sold my heart
I didn't care anymore if it was pride or heart disease

He also expresses a nihilistic attitude towards life, saying how he needs to stop thinking because he'll die sooner or later anyways.

The next letter is 4/20, which is of little significance other than how he's writing the next song while thinking about him and Elma's time in Sekimachi, which is supposedly the town they met in. The song is Shikaki to Coffee, dated 4/24. The lyrics are, once more, about how he struggled to cope with his parting with Elma (you should quickly learn that this is the main theme of both albums) as well as how his heart has hardened. He mentions his very poor living standards, and also alludes to his inability to say goodbye, later revealed to be both literal and internal. He's basically a real mess without Elma and is forced to start his life back from square one, demonstrated by the line where he ponders how people know how to walk so easily. The most important lyrics of note is this:

As I'm forgetting my dreams and how ephemeral things are and your mouth and eyes and fingertips
Look, soon it'll be time for my songs to come to an end
Because it's finally your turn now

Next is 7/13, where the chronological order starts getting weird. Here Amy talks about his strange, self-admittedly religious belief regarding music. Amy believes that God lies in the ways in which emotion is conveyed, particularly in works of art. He values the expression of art more than human expression itself. The letter ends with Amy commenting on how he's running out of ink.

Then follows Odorou ze, 6/15. The tone of this song is overwhelmingly 'resignation'. It's basically about Amy trying to repress the fact that he longs for Elma and forcing himself to adopt an 'it is what it is' attitude https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EoP1NEGIpwU. This is why the title is "Let's Dance", acting like everything is fine and dancing when things are definitely not fine which is basically the typical party experience.

Next up is 5/17. Amy talks about the town he's in (he does in basically every letter, if I didn't mention that) and then goes on to talk about an element in the song he wrote a few days prior, later revealed to be Gogatsu wa Hana Rokushou no Madobe kara. He talks about a dye called paris green, which is also highly poisonous and used to kill rats. He reveals how he compares tears to paris green (also called emerald green) in the song, and basically goes on a slightly unstable rant about how tears are weakness that protect people from the harshness of reality, believing this to be a narcissist self-defense mechanism. To him, tears are poison. He remarks on how he wishes he understood that "back then" and avoided this weakness. This is a not so subtle sign that Amy was once a very sensitive person who cried a lot (for reasons revealed later), but has since then hardened his heart, as seen in Shikaki to Coffee and Odorou ze thus far. The song following this letter is Rokugatsu wa Ameagari no Machi wo Kaku, dated 5/31. It is, expectedly, more suffering trying to cope with his memories of Elma. This time he's particularly depressed by his inability to communicate with Elma. A line does reveal the meaning of Ai Nijou however:

My life now is i^2
Subtracting you left me below zero
I can only see you in my memories
In the aftermath of the June rain

In Japanese, Ai Nijou literally means “Indigo^2”, however Ai is a homophone with i, the imaginary number, therefore i^2 (if you don’t know, i^2 = -1). This is basically saying that he was already an empty person, but now that Elma’s gone he’s in the negatives. Also, importantly, Rokugatsu is the first song (other than 1 line in the ending section of Hachigatsu) that alludes to “that summer”, something that will be repeatedly brought up in later songs.

Up next is the notorious 5/29, where we get to hear about Henry Darger. Henry Darger was a real artist, who was basically unknown during his life and worked as a janitor, but after his death left a 15,000 page manuscript and hundreds of hand painted illustrations to go along with his story. He never wanted them to be published. Amy expresses how this is the highest ideal for any artist, in another slightly unhinged monologue. He talks about how he always wanted fame and was jealous at other people’s success, but has now changed his mind and admires Darger’s way of living, saying he’s been doing it wrong the whole time. This is again, not so subtly, another coping mechanism for his lack of success as an artist. Following 5/29 is what I consider to be among the best Yorushika songs lyrically, Gogatsu wa Hana Rokushou no Madobe kara, dated 5/15. The song is about Amy’s struggle to reconcile his own personal meaning of music (as represented by Darger’s ideal) and his own desire for recognition in his music, as well as his intense sensitivity to criticism. As hinted throughout, music is virtually the only way for Amy to express his emotions while also serving as his only way to properly cope with and remember his memories of Elma. He wants to share his music with the public, but gets critiqued as most people just don’t understand what he’s trying to convey, understandably. Even though he believes himself to be making art for art’s sake (his own sake), he’s very hurt by people’s reactions and feels the need to try again in order to be heard, like an abusive relationship.

"I remembered," I screamed from my throat
This pain itself is my proof of you
Even so,
Even so, if you insist that you can't hear it...

There are honestly so many good lines to point out that I think you just need to go read it yourself. Virtually every part of the song is heart wrenching and beautiful.

The next letter is 6/26, where Amy elaborates more on his struggle as an artist. He cites his primary motivation to write music as rage. He wants to rebel against the people who made fun of his music, and openly shares how he hates these guys so much he wants to kill them. He recalls a time shortly after he quit his job when he was playing on the street (he was rarely ever noticed) when a middle aged man actually stopped and listened to his whole song. The man's only remark was that it was boring, and then left. Amy rhetorically asks what he thought at that time, answering it by writing "I didn't care" in huge letters. Sure buddy, whatever you say. That was also the last time he played his music in public. Ouch. The song following this is Yoru Magai, dated 7/11. This song deals with familiar themes of Amy being unable to focus on anything but Elma, but also turns attention to the ways in which he wants to be remembered. Amy writes about how he wants to make an impact on people, equating his life to a machine gun trying to make impressions on other people by shooting them. At the end he gives a line seemingly directly targeted at Elma:

I wanna become a memory for you, that lives by passing it onto the next generation, I feel like just watching hurts
Just one is enough, once is enough for you
I wanna open a hole in you*

*this line in japanese means both "I wanna put a bullet through you" and "I wanna breathe new life into you".

This of course ties in to how Amy believes God resides in works of art, and he can in some way live through his art. In another part of the song he also mentions his disgust with himself for having to sing at a bar to make a living instead of singing for its own sake.

The next letter is 5/6. Amy writes about how the only possessions he has left are one bottle of ink (the others were stolen), a fountain pen, paper and his guitar. He ponders whether life has an expiration date or not, calling back to Ai Nijou. He then ominously remarks how his love for music faded 2 or 3 years after he started, and he already thinks that it's past its expiration date. Yet he can't help but make music as a way to live, contrasting his life to a bike without wheels.

The letter is Parade, dated 7/12, which is rather short lyrically due to the slow pace of the song. Parade directly confronts Amy's reason for making music as a way to store his memories with Elma, and his franticness to do so before he forgets them (or expires himself). It also calls back to how Amy believes that God is contained within art, now directly tracing it to the fingers that write lyrics and the voice that sings them (Elma's voice particularly). He is more or less saying that he thinks Elma is divine to him. Heart warming, but also absolutely crushing. There is a strange line though:

In the depths of my body, right below the throat
Are the days of imitating the songs you wrote

This seems to be referring to Elma's songs. But just what connection does Elma's songs have with Amy? Hmm. Hmmmmmmmm. Of course, this will be answered in due time.

In the next letter, 8/8 (the ink starts getting faint around here), Amy explains what the 27 club is, as mentioned in Hachigatsu, Bou, Tsukiakari. There is a myth (or a curse) that all great rock musicians die at 27, as many of them actually have. Amy takes this into consideration and ponders the short but sweet life of the 27 club, asking himself if he would die without trying to become a great musician or try to join the ranks of the greats himself. He then reveals that he already thought about this and decided to give his all to music. It was actually what spurred him to leave everything and go on this trip through Sweden in the first place, to live his entire life in the span of a year. At the end of the letter, he importantly states that he "finally remembered that time", referring to some event with Elma that took place under moonlight. The proceeding song is titled Elma, dated 8/31, the latest of all the songs and the date of the very first letter. The lyrics detail an idyllic summer scene spent with Elma, and the song itself reflects that with a slightly whimsical but deeply melancholic tone. Amy knows it's time to say goodbye to Elma within himself, but in the end (and also later to be revealed, AT the end) he just can't quite give up that summer scene.

I know I'm a liar, I feel it
Still Elma, it still hurts
So sing goodbye already

Until the darkening night falls

Not related to the summary, but the current only available translation has many contextual errors so even if you're familiar with the lyrics already, go give my version a read in the full document for Amy's letters. It also has some nice wordplay that I give commentary for.

The next letter was written on the day that Amy left for his journey, 4/10. The only things packed are "bare essential luggage, an ink bottle, a fountain pen, a camera, an acoustic guitar, and a plain wooden box to hold the songs [he'll] write." He's aware at this point that things will end at the end of the coming summer and calls it his life's final journey. By the way he writes, it's shown that he originally didn't intend to send the letters to Elma, that was only a decision made later (which will very soon be shown).

So. Before we enter the final song, I'll recap some points just to make sure that you, the reader, understand what's happened. If you haven't yet figured it out, Amy is dying of a terminal illness, some heart disease, and has little time to live. With this fact in mind, he decided to use his time to go on a journey to live out his artistic ideal, knowing he won't make it past the summer, where if he did nothing and stayed in Japan he probably could have lived for some time longer with Elma. As shown by 8/8 and 4/10, it was a sudden decision that he did in a day essentially, without informing Elma. There's also plenty of contextual evidence that another reason (perhaps the main reason) he left suddenly without saying anything was to spare Elma the pain of having to watch him slowly die, instead leaving the products of his Sweden journey (his songs) to remember him by. If the relationship between Amy and Elma is vague and confusing, don't worry, that will be explained pretty much at the start of Elma's diary. With all this said, let's continue.

The final song is the titular one, Dakara Boku wa Ongaku wo Yameta, dated 8/25. This one's a real doozy to understand. There's actually musical hints that help understand the meaning of the lyrics. Most of the song is written from the perspective of the Amy of 4/10, and his thought process leading up to his decision to abandon everything and leave on this journey. This is shown by the fact that in the album 4/10 precedes it, and the piano in that song flows right into

dakaboku. In fact, when the piano drops from the foreground in the song, it's usually accompanied by a shift to the perspective of Amy at 8/25. Here's an example of the shift:

I thought about it and still don't get it Youth is just so boring
I quit the piano already, but I can't break the habit of playing it on my desk
Hey, what will I be doing in the future I sure hope it isn't music ...Don't worry about that

Clearly these are the thoughts of 4/10 Amy, as 8/25 Amy is quite aware that he doesn't have a future. To the undecided 4/10 Amy, his future was still uncertain. Also, the piano is playing in the foreground until...

Even when I drawn a line in my heart, it just wouldn't disappear
Hey, it's already too late, so… don't remember it!

Here. The latter line in particular is the internal conflict of 4/10 Amy who had wanted to give up everything for music, and 8/25 Amy who at this point has some strong sentiments in regards to his past naivety by leaving Elma, and with her his reason to live. Hence "it's already too late, don't remember it". Basically, Amy is haunted by the fact that just now at the end of his life he's considering the alternative and wondering whether his choice was right or not.
The parts written by 4/10 Amy most detail his lack of care for anything but music, but his reluctance to throw everything away for it. As the song goes on, 8/25 Amy's voice becomes stronger, show here with:

I thought about it and still don't get it Just living is painful
I can't write music anymore, I don't care if the lyrics are sloppy I just don't care
^ This could be attributed to either 4/10 or 8/25 Amy ^

I'm not mistaken right I'm not mistaken, am I?
^ 8/25 Amy attempting to agree with 4/10 Amy and stick by his decision ^

I'm mistaken, I know it already! All you humans
true love, salvation, kindness, life, I don't care about it

^ 8/25 Amy knowing that he's wrong but can't take it back ^

As you can probably tell, there's lots of room for interpretation with this song so please give it a read yourself! I have another theory that's probably just as likely, that it does deal with multiple time frames but this song is actually written from the perspective of Amy who had already given up on music, whenever that was (this will be explained in the next letter), and it's ultimately about how a certain thing happened with a certain someone that motivated him to dedicated himself to music again. Whether the 4/10 Amy is theory is true or the Amy who had quit music theory is true, I'm pretty sure this following part is from 8/25 Amy's perspective, and is probably the most poignant, emotionally moving section (out of the lyrics) in the album:

Even I once had something I believed in, though now the sentiment is like garbage
When I wrote about you again and again, I didn't care whether or not it sold
It's true, it's really true It really was like that

That's why I

That's why I quit music

And so we have reached the final letter of Dakaboku. It is 8/31, the same date as the first letter, though clearly written afterwards. This is written at the end of Amy's life, as he's running out of the last of his ink, yet finds it in him to drop some critical truth bombs at the end. First, a tear-jerker:

The songs I've put in this box are a single work that symbolizes me.
You could say that the music is itself my very life.
Elma, I could never give it to anyone but you.

Amy changes his mind and decides to give the box with all of his songs, photos, and letters to Elma, finally accepting her as what's truly important to him. He stated it as early as Ai Nijou: Elma was his music. Therefore, to dedicate his life to music is to dedicate his life to Elma, a fact

he finally recognizes. Calling himself a liar in Elma (written on the same day, 8/31) is likely his acceptance of the fact that he's been deceiving himself of her importance to him this entire time. As he was not planning to mail the box, he simply puts her address on it and hopes someone will understand to mail it when they find it.

Amy then goes on to recall that he originally wanted to be a pianist, and only became a musician because he couldn't bring himself to give up his other desire of being an "author". So he compromised by becoming a lyricist, remarking that his life has been nothing but a series of compromises, again calling back to Ai Nijou. Then Amy drops the real reveal.

In the past he had once quit music, but started writing again when he heard **Elma's** songs.

You didn't show me often, but that time when I felt you through your song, I saw the moonlight.

The unerring, faultless light that can only illuminate the night.

Unimaginably soft, dazzling beyond my wildest dreams, pale moonlight

And thus ends Amy's letters. All of Amy's obsession and eccentrics regarding music can be traced back to the inspiration he received from Elma, the moonlight. It should also go without saying that Amy's life ended on 8/31, when he finally ran out of ink, as without the ability to write music he had nothing else to live for. Music had its meaning for Amy because of its relation to Elma, so without music there was nothing left. i^2. And because I think it's not mentioned in Elma's diary I'll write it here, Amy killed himself by ingesting paris green (the poison) and then falling into the sea. I believe that's only revealed in the Nautilus music video. As to when Amy had quit music in the past, I believe it's up for debate. It may have been some time around 4/10, before it, or even after that. I'd be interested to hear people's take on it.

Now onto Elma's diary! Honestly it's much more direct than Amy's rather cryptic writing, so it should be easier to understand. It is however longer, as it contains more actual plot.

Elma's Diary

A little note on the structure of Elma's diary. It doesn't just have dated letters and songs like in Amy's letters, but also includes memories numbered 1-19. The memories are, as you might guess, memories from the past about Amy. The dated letters are about present day Elma and her taking the same trip Amy did a year later. Her diary opens with memory 1, recalling Amy's views on God residing in works. She references a story about a giant salamander trapping a frog in a grotto, whilst also being trapped itself, and compares this to Amy's works blocking memories of him from escaping. She ends by stating that Amy is the closest thing to God for her.

The first letter is 3/14, which just details Elma leaving for Sweden. Then we get the first song, Yuu Ichijou dated 9/15. All the songs in Elma parallel a song in Dakaboku, with Yuu Ichijou paralleling Ai Nijou. Like Ai Nijou, Yuu Ichijou introduces the themes of Elma. It has many details, but it mostly all ties back into Elma's difficulty in coping with the loss of Amy (and frustration with her lack of resolution with him on a personal level), and her confusion regarding his legacy. A fairly important imagery that's introduced is of Elma being stuck at the bottom of a lake, representing her memories, with the words she speaks (and the emotions being conveyed) being trapped within bubbles.

It's like I'm at the bottom of a lake
My wet eardrums start to itch
Expectations, the future, tomorrow - I didn't want to hear any of it
The bubbles leaving my mouth are so pretty

So it seems that Elma is not doing very well without Amy.

Similarly to Amy, Elma mentions stuff about the town she's in in pretty much every letter which I will be omitting unless it's important. Next is 3/21 and 3/22. Elma talks about how her motivation to keep the diary is to store memories of Amy before she forgets, and that she re-reads his letters almost every day. The following song is Yuunagi, Bou, Hana Madoi (3/22)

which obviously parallels Hachigatsu, Bou, Tsukiakari. The summer imagery is full force in this song.

I'll put it into words one more time
Remember that certain August day
To me, it's full of things I can never say enough about

The purpose of Yuunagi seems to be to put her memories of a certain summer sunset scene with Amy into song as a method of recording it, hence the repeating line of "just remembering isn't enough". Though she also makes it clear that remembering itself is difficult for her, and ends the song by alluding to how she also wants to forget it and move on:

Just singing songs isn't enough
Through the song of the days with you dyed in the red sunset
I want to know a beautiful night
Lost in flowers,
I wait for summer while being bathed in the moonlight

Seeing as how night follows sunset, wanting to know a beautiful night can be equated to getting over her memories of that day. By the way, the phrase "lost in flowers" in japanese is hana madou, the same as the hana madoi in the title, which alludes to being entranced by fireworks (in japanese, fireworks are called hanabi literally meaning "flower fire").

3/23 contains more mostly pointless Sweden stuff, but is followed by memory 2 which describes how Elma met Amy. She was going home when she went into a cafe to shelter from the rain. There she saw Amy writing songs and she was entranced by him. He put his head on the table to rest, and then a song he had thrown away drifted over to Elma's seat. She picked it up and read it, then Amy woke up and noticed her. The rest is history, it seems. After memory 2 is 4/5, where she talks about a real life poet admiring a past poet's style to the point they adopt it themselves. This, of course, is alluding to herself and Amy. The next song is Ame to Cappuccino, 9/3, which parallels Shikaki to Coffee. The song recalls her first meeting with Amy, and is pretty clearly about the creation of songs to cap off her memories of Amy, analogizing it to an overflowing coffee cup. The imagery is pretty direct to be honest, so there's not too much to say in my opinion. We do, however, get our first hint of some independency problems, which

should become clear going forward:

It's always been so strange
I've only ever wanted to be taught a single way to live
Even though I don't have anything left to pay you back with
If you're not going to answer, then just a single word is okay
I don't understand
I really don't understand

Next comes memory 3, which details more of Amy's strangely impoverished lifestyle, living in a small apartment with very few things in it. Elma mentions how he was obsessed with the word "pointless", and theorizes that he wished to remove all the pointless things from his life. Elma probably theorized that this includes herself… ouch. This is also where it's mentioned that Amy would write songs in previously blank entries in his diary, which potentially messes up the chronology of Dakaboku. After this is 5/1 and 5/15. 5/1 has Elma confessing to her attempts to imitate Amy's song writing, hilariously pointing out some meta-commentary on n-buna's writing style (always using boku, saying 'I don't care', and constantly focusing on memories and yearning for summer). In 5/15, Elma stresses that her now lost sense of urgency in life is giving her some problems, as without being constantly pushed to achieve her goals she's left focusing on a much more difficult challenge: her own self. She also reveals that it was her who put the idea of life having an expiration date into Amy's head. Oops. Then comes Kami-sama no Dance, dated 5/28, which again parallels Odorou ze. Elma's saltiness is definitely shown in this song throughout various points. It turns out that idolizing Amy is not very healthy considering his values. Some examples:

It's only when you've thrown away your words, your way of life, and your courtesy
That music is made
How could you, who doesn't know the value of any of those things,
ever understand?

If you're free to choose your own values,
then you're free to hurt others too, right?
Weren't you the one who never taught me that?

To forget is horrible, isn't it?
As if it could make anyone happy
Weren't you the one who made me twisted enough to think that?

In short, Elma is imitating Amy in everything, and yet she's simply a different person who isn't Amy, so she has a lot of trouble adopting his ideas particularly in regards to abandoning everything for music. We get a personal line about Elma here:

I don't want people to laugh at me
So I look down, like I'm scared
Are you really expecting me to believe
That there's anything more important than the heart?

This is a nice contrast with Amy. As shown here and in other parts to come, Elma has confidence issues in regards to both music and expressing her own will. Amy is in a way equally sensitive in the way others view his music, but rather than cowering he feels rage and anger. Not that he's any less hurt of course, he's just more willing to put himself out there than Elma.

Memory 4 is a heart crushing account of how Elma wished she could have joined Amy when he ran away, saying that she'd be okay with abandoning everything to be with him, even if it meant struggling financially and living in a foreign country. To her, Amy was the only thing necessary. From 6/15 to 6/29 Elma stays in Gamla Stan waiting for it to rain because Amy was going to write a song about Gamla Stan after the rain, but didn't stay long enough to actually see said sight, as shown in Rokugatsu wa Ameagari no Michi wo Kaku. She wants to know why. In the meantime, Elma does mention various memories of Amy though. There was a time that Amy read her writing and said "I'm jealous", which she thought was a joke (it wasn't), and another memory of Elma seeing him enter a hospital. She also wonders if Amy was fed up with her due to how attached she was, but ends by saying that now she doesn't understand anything about how he felt or what he left. Clearly she didn't read Loafer's guide to Letters to Elma. Rain finally comes to Gamla Stan after a bizarre scene where Elma follows a jolly naked child through the twisting streets to find a bench with a statue of said child next to it (implying the child was the statue). ...I don't know either. But then we reach memory 5, which details how Amy and Elma

would go play piano in a basically empty public hall when it would rain. Amy was always very supportive of her even when she was learning, clapping after every performance and always being very into the music. Then one day he stopped playing the piano. Finally, on 6/29 the rain stops and we get our next song, Ame Haruru dated 6/30, obviously paralleling Rokugatsu. The lyrics are a mixed bag of heartfelt longing for Amy (and her dependency on him, with the chorus saying that her entire life is just him) and intense resentment for the pain he causes her. The summer memory of swaying curtains in an empty classroom that was mention in Gogatsu gets referenced again here:

A white curtain swayed
It swayed softly, swaying me
Swaying love

My theory is what happened in said empty summer classroom while looking at the sky with one another is what got Elma to fall in love with Amy (and probably vice versa, to be honest). The love theme is pretty intense in this song.

The only thing of note that happens in 7/2, 7/5, and 7/6 is Elma helping an old woman out who shows her a picture of 2 older women and an elderly man, but due to the language barrier she doesn't know what she's trying to say and is left speculating as to who they are and what the 3's relationship is. Then comes Aruku, 7/8, paralleling Gogatsu wa Hana Rokushou no Madobe kara. Lyrically, there's not much to say about this song in my opinion. It's basically just about Elma expressing how she is only going through the motions of life without actually having a reason for living. In other words: depression. However, it's revealed that Elma knew what Amy was going through as well:

Writing those sorrow-tinged songs
With emerald green trailing your cheeks
To tell the truth, I always knew everything

Next is memory 6. It contains Amy's thoughts on talent. Most of it is the usual vague poetry of how talent is always there but fragile, but most importantly he ends the talk by

disregarding talent and focusing on how everything can have value if you choose to perceive the beauty in it, and that all works are equal. Elma lampshades how this is contradictory with his other viewpoints by ending the memory with “I don’t get it, Amy.” 7/10 and 7/12 are just about her traveling to Visby, then comes memory 7. Elma noticed one day that Amy was playing weakly and forcing himself to hide his illness. He mentions how Elma has gotten as good as him, which she denies. Amy then goes on a wild philosophical line regarding the nature of music, eventually concluding that even silence is a form of music, and then wondering if there is a god of art that assigns an objective value to all music, and what sort of value his music might have. Elma is confused by this, and he then returns to normal. However, that was the last time she saw him.

The next song is Kokoro ni Ana ga Aita, 9/6, paralleling Yoru Magai. In my opinion, this is probably the most depressing Yorushika song that’s not from Tousaku. Elma’s identity crisis is in full force here. She’s got problems, to say the least. The song more or less demonstrates how Elma had devoted so much to Amy that when he left she was just left with nothing but her underdeveloped self. She tried to replace the parts of herself that she lost with Amy by *literally becoming him*.

I want to write about my life, the life I wanted to give to you
It's all because of the songs you left me
It's all music's fault

I copied your habits of speech
and I tried to imitate your way of life
Until nothing was left, until all of me was blasted away
But I'm still here

Pardon my french, but that’s some real hard shit. And in case that wasn’t hard enough:

I never want to hear "goodbye" for the rest of my life
There's so much that I want to forget
From here on out, only I will grow older
I'm growing colder, I'm growing colder

Just… just oww. The growing colder here refers to her losing her feelings for Amy as she ages. No matter how much she wants to forget, the only thing that can fill the hole in her heart is Amy. We also get to see her reach the same conclusion that Amy did for her:

A hole opened in my heart
A hole opened because of your words
I understand now
That "you alone are my music," Amy

Overall, Elma's extreme loneliness and, quite frankly, inability to live on her own is pervasive all throughout the song.

Elma admits that she can't live like Henry Darger, wanting fame to give her some satisfaction in life. In 7/22, Elma finds herself in a cemetery where she meets the old woman from before. She's come to tend to a grave, and signals to Elma that it's her dead husband. Elma reflects on Amy:

Everything past that day seems blurred. Everything sounds like it's distorted. It's like I've been left behind, all alone at the bottom of a lake.

Then the woman gives a handkerchief to Elma without saying a word. Clearly there's dead lover solidarity here. Next is memory 8, where Elma recalls actually receiving Amy's box. He mailed it to her grandma as that was the only address of Elma's he knew. Elma comments that the cafe they met at had been torn down and replaced already. "From that day forward, my eyes have always been seeing a dream". Memory 9 continues, with Elma admitting that she doesn't understand the value of the letters, even after nearly memorizing them, as she can't think for herself without Amy. Even after going all these lengths to imitate him, "nothing has changed. Nothing comes to mind". This leads into Koe, dated 7/28, which pairs with Parade. And like Parade, it's lyrically quite short. It's even thematically similar to Parade, dealing with her desire to remember Amy, though the reasoning is different. On one hand she wants to get over it all, but on the other she doesn't yet understand anything of what he said or wrote so she feels the need to

imitate him further.

No matter what I do, I can't touch them
No matter what, I can't see their shape
I want to remember
Those easy-to-forget habits just a little longer

Because I don't understand

There's also a callback to Parade's analogy of Elma's voice to God, shown here:

When I speak, it always come out
But even if it does, it quickly disappears
When I cry, it overflows
And if I stay silent, it's still there deep within my throat
It's the talk of Gods

It's a while until the next song, so strap in. 7/30 details a dream that Elma had. She walks with Amy to a church in a forest with crepe myrtles blooming on each side (important for understanding the EPs), and then enters the church and finds herself on a beach. She begins to make a doll out of wet sand, one with Amy's face. Obviously the sand will dry and the doll will crumble, which causes her to rush in its creation. This of course is a metaphor for how she's creating a version of Amy within herself to remember him, but the memories it's built from are transient and fading. Elma then realizes she's dreaming and wakes up in a cafe in the rain. Later, Elma casually reveals how she can no longer taste food, which is in fact a symptom of severe depression.

In memory 10, Elma recounts the day Amy left. She was, naturally, incredibly distressed and searched for him crying all the while. But then she reveals that deep down she also felt relief in not having to watch him slowly suffer and die, and she believes that Amy knew she feared having to witness that and left as an act of kindness. Little did he know however, that denying that goodbye would hamstring Elma on a personal level.

I haven't changed at all. All I do is cling to what he left behind. This heart that's given up walking on its own is filled with an emptiness that just keeps expanding. I can't escape the grotto - just like that giant salamander, I'm completely stuck in place.

She also just casually mentions how she's stuck clinging to Amy's diary… that she stole from his room. Well, alright then.

From 8/8 to 8/26 the entries get progressively shorter, as well as her thoughts getting simpler. She states the reason as nothing coming to mind, as she's used up all of her memories of Amy. To show the level of bin-scraping in terms of memories, she writes about how bad of a cook Amy was after eating some sliced bread, which she'd do with him in the past. The entries become as short as "Can't write anything".

The next entry, 8/27, is a two parter and quite surreal, definitely a blend of fantasy and reality. Elma leaves town to depart to the church in the forest, which probably does not exist, where she gets lost in the woods essentially. She then is convinced she sees Amy's shadow, and chases after him. She's led out of the woods and ends up on a beach, and the figure from the forest is revealed to be a glorious stag. It's a deserted, unpopular sort of beach with a lone pier, which she heads to. She recalls Amy's phrase of "The value of a life is in the way it ends", and states how it carried her this far. At the edge of the pier she asks herself if this was how Amy felt (preparing to kill himself), and jumps off. As she sinks to the bottom, she finds Amy's fountain pen. 8/27 part 2 continues with her returning to shore and finding his ink bottle as well, along with a bag containing his notebook. Amy would write drafts on paper first before copying them into his notebook, so what Elma was sent were the first drafts, and this notebook was the real thing.

Next is memory 10. Elma starts by revealing her personal weakness, hating herself for being a push-over, essentially. It's revealed that it was Amy who named Elma (it isn't her real name), and he describes her as a crybaby who tries to resist her cowardly nature, and a good songwriter. Amy is also not his real name; it's his initials. Amy then tells Elma that no one can judge her true value but the god of art, and asks her what she wants to do and what she wants to find. The memory ends by Elma beginning her response before cutting off.

Memory 12 describes Elma going through Amy's notebook, where a surprisingly important piece of information is revealed:

There are several songs that weren't in the letters, inserted in between.

A song about the sun after the rain. A song about sleeping in the winter, waiting for summer. A song calling himself a loser. The dates are all over the place, and what comes after is light, thinly penned - but always lined up, dignified.

This is referencing some of the songs from the EPs. Indeed, the EPs (Natsukusa ga Jama wo Suru and Makeinu ni Encore wa Iranai) are written by Amy and Elma. That's a whole other can of worms, but it's nice to know the connection between the albums and the EP. The contents of the notebook are mostly the same as the letters, with the differences coming in the songs at the end. Only in the notebook does Elma find the song, Elma, written by Amy on 8/31. The effect it has on her is hard to imagine. Following this we finally have our next song (and the last one written by Elma): Amy, written 9/16.

We've been so full of misunderstandings, I have one more story to tell before it's too late

Obviously, it parallels Elma the song. This is a unique song, and you could even say that it's the first song that Elma's written on her own, artistically speaking. To compound this, this song is written in a different handstyle, what is likely Elma's true handstyle, implying she's been imitating Amy's this entire time. It's also one of the very few Yorushika songs that's actually upbeat (Yay!). In it, Elma finally comes to accept that though Amy is gone he still lives on through her, particularly through music. Amy's constant mentioning of how God resides in Elma's creative potential seems to finally have gotten through.

Come, even though life is stupid through and through
Just with the moving white clouds above
My imagination is reproducing you
You forever exist in that summer

This encapsulates Elma's new attitude towards her memories of Amy. There definitely seems to be a sort of existentialist tone as well.

It's alright now

Now then, listen up! This song is the last, after all
Even if you don't say anything
Like it or not, life is something that ends
So just sing already!

Elma's internal conflict of both wanting to forget to remove the pain, but not wanting to forget because the memories are precious, has been resolved with this. Also of note:

At this point, see
At this point, as you wander in the cracks of
A pale summer somewhere far away

The cracks of pale summer references the fantasy Amy had in Elma (the song), alluding to how in the same way Elma lived in that fantasy for Amy, Amy will live in that fantasy for Elma. The fantasy in this case being song itself. This seems like a conclusive resolution, but there's still more to come (this was written 9/16, Elma discovered the diary on 8/27 so there's still 20 days to go).

After Amy comes memory 13. It starts with Amy asking Elma where the most beautiful music in the world comes from, before answering it by pointing to her head. He talks about how he views the mind as floating in a sea of imagination, with the creation process being taking stones (representing words) and crafting them into a gem. Elma was inspired by this imagery.

Why had I forgotten?
Why didn't I stop to properly think about it?
With this head, with the eyes you taught me to see with.

Amy, why did it get so,
Amy, I

And so we reach the final song. Nautilus, dated… nothing. This is the only song without a date. I'll say it ahead of time for clarity of understanding, this song was written by Amy. It's a bit of a

weird one, but the purpose of it is very clear. This is Amy's final message to Elma. That message is, essentially, "Though it may take time, say goodbye to me and look towards the future".

Lift your head at the speed of farewell
Someday dawn will finally break
Come on, open your eyes
And see that I've been imagining your sleepy eyes so many times

A good portion of the song describes Amy's lackadaisical musings about the plans of an ordinary day, trying to avoid social interaction. This is in order to set up these lines:

At this speed I swim through today,
And if my hand finally touches you
Then come on, open your eyes
Because I remember that I had forgotten your sleepy eyes

And this chorus is repeated with a change in the last line:

Then come on, open your eyes
And see how I forgot you

The speed at which he "swims" through the day is one of slow progress, signalling to Elma that her life is long and with many possibilities, unlike his which he limits to a single day here and still takes a lax attitude towards. The image of Elma's sleeping eyes represents how she isn't looking forward in life. The line "Because I remember that I forgot your sleepy eyes" is referring to how, until the last moment, Amy had forgotten to consider how Elma would feel after he's gone. And now that he has, he's writing this song to take responsibility and open her eyes, metaphorically, to a life without him. There is a rather interesting part that references something also mentioned in Aruku.

There you are in front of the hill, laughing, "It's been so long, hasn't it?" as you bring your face close to mine

"Let's go together," you say

In Aruku, there is also a line that mentions Elma imagining Amy in front of a hill, wondering what can be seen beyond it. So this hill is definitely a shared memory between Elma and Amy, but as to what it actually is I don't know. There might be some mention of it in the EPs, and if I find anything I'll add it here. The next couple of lines has a reference (a title drop, actually) to Natsukusa ga Jama wo Suru, so it's possible.

Though that was the last song, there is still more to go. 9/3 has Elma mentioning how she writes Ame to Cappuccino in the margins of her notebook, revealing that some of the songs were retroactively written into the diary. This continues to 9/5 with Yuu Ichijou, 9/6 with Kokoro ni Ana ga Aita, and so on. Memories 14 through 19 are inserted in between these entries. They mostly recall aspects of Amy's personality, and his kindness. She mentions how Amy would always treat her gently, how she was happy hearing his songs because they revealed his weakness a bit, multiple instances of him encouraging her to be proud of her music and talent, and so on. It's also revealed that the memories are retroactively written in as well: she had forgotten all of them until she read Amy's journal. Basically, she's in a sort of frenzy of writing down memories and songs, being overwhelmed by it all. Memory 17 reveals the memory that inspired both Elma and Amy to write Hachigatsu and Yuunagi. In August some years prior, they had watched fireworks together off of a veranda while writing songs. 9/8 is about how Elma found Nautilus. She returned to the beach and found another pier, more dilapidated than the last, and on it was a guitar case with the song in it. Memory 19 is only one sentence simply saying "Elma, become a kind person".

In 9/10, Elma expresses her confusion towards the way Amy viewed her, not understanding the moonlight (aka musical talent, artistic beauty, etc) that he saw in her. She claims that she never had a reason to write songs before now, and only went on the journey to satisfy herself. 9/11 is also a single sentence, "I finally understand". The next day in 9/12 she addresses her entry to Amy, telling him that she's finally found something she truly wants to do: write music for all the songs he left behind. Before that point, she was only drawn to music out of admiration for the world that Amy saw, but now she wishes to make music to carry on his legacy and discover "the light he saw within [her]". She does so not wishing for any fame or recognition, just for her and

his sake alone, also conceding that it will likely take a long time but she's motivated to see it all the way through.

9/14, the second to last entry, has Elma announcing her conclusion of the diary, quoting Amy saying "a story that never ends is boring". The final entry, 9/25, describes Elma departing on a boat. As she's leaving she sees the grandma from before with her children (or grandchildren), and Elma notices a man supporting her by her side. The diary ends with Elma looking out over the sunset horizon, recalling Amy's description of it as a night imitation.

And so ends the diary. The message at the end is a bit of a tough one to swallow, but a realistic and necessary one. The grandma showing her second husband is a pretty clear signal that Elma will eventually move on and find someone new. You could say that these 2 albums are a very extended story that more or less covers everything you'll ever need to know about dealing with partings and goodbyes A to Z. There's still some questions to be answered, such as why Amy didn't include the song Elma (and especially Nautilus!) in the box to Elma. But hopefully this guide has helped string together the story, and provide some thematic analysis. The links to both Letters to Elma and Elma's diary are at the top for you to review the source material and make your own analysis as you desire.